On the discussion questions regarding Strawson's 'On Referring' (December 10, 2025)

Here are a couple of thoughts and observations on the discussion questions. As always, comments are welcome!

All groups:
"Russell or Strawson? (Or neither?) Why?"

We will leave this one open.

Group 1:
"Can Strawson's distinction between meaning and use be meaningfully generalised to encompasses all expressions and all sentences? (For example, does the meaning - use distinction make sense for adjectives? Or for prepositions?)"

First, note that in order to address this issue we need to extend the concept of use as Strawson defines it. For him it covers only the case of uniquely referring to an individual, so for other types of expressions it needs to be broadened. Let's for the moment understand by 'use' of an expression *A* in the context of a sentence *S* an act of establishing a reference of *A* in order to ensure that *S* is something that is 'truth-evaluable', i.e., something for which the question whether it is true or false makes sense. In other words, the use of *A* is such that it makes it possible to assign a truth value to *S*.[1] It will be clear that this extended conception of use covers Strawson's uniquely referring use as a subcase.

Can this conception of use and the dissociation between meaning and use that Strawson connects with it, be applied across various categories of expressions? Here we need to take a step back and consider context-dependence in general. It will be clear that use-dependence is an instance of context-dependence, in the obvious sense that use is an aspect of context. However, the key issue is which aspects of context-dependence are part of meaning and which can only be attributed to use.

As an example, consider the adjective 'tall'. This is a relative adjective, i.e., an adjective that expresses, not an absolute property, but one that is relative to some comparison class. We say that John is tall for a 12-year-old, but at the same time we can also say that he is not tall for a basketball player. Depending on whom we compare John with, he may count as tall or not, as the case may be. Lots of adjectives express properties that are relative in this sense, for example adjectives such as 'expensive', 'tasty', 'close to', 'precise'. And a similar observation can be made with regard to adverbs such as 'precisely', 'surprisingly', 'quickly', and so on. These are all expressions that require a comparison class that is contextually determined. (J.L. Austin famously made the case for the adjective 'hexagonal' as it appears in 'France is hexagonal'.[2] Is it? Well, that depends on what shape you associate with the country and that is also a matter of context, i.e., of the purpose of the description and the precision that is required.)

What the comparison class is with respect to which the property expressed by a relative adjective is ascribed (or denied) does not seem to be a matter of the use that the speaker makes of the adjective, but rather an aspect of the meaning of relative adjectives as such. I.e., the dependence on a comparison class is like the dependence on the speaker that is part of the meaning of 'I'.

[1] Should we want to apply the Strawsonian concept of use also to (expressions occurring in) sentences that are not used to make statements, such as interrogatives or imperatives, a further extension is needed. But we will leave that out of consideration.
[2] In his *How to Do Things with Words*, Oxford, Clarendon, 1962.

Here are two reasons for thinking so. First of all, the dependence on a comparison class can be made explicit: we can turn the relative adjective into an absolute one by explicitly mentioning a comparison class: 'tall for a 12-year-old', 'tall for a basketball player' are absolute properties, at least as far as the comparison that is part of 'tall' is concerned. Secondly, when left implicit, the comparison class is determined by context but not by the use made of the expression by the speaker. When there is no need to mention it explicitly, what the comparison class is will be evident from the context in an intersubjective sense. All speech participants are assumed to have access to it, and if they don't, they can ask.

There are other reasons, however, to think that dependence on use in the sense described above (as part of the determination of the truth-evaluable meaning of the sentences in which they occur) *can* occur with adjectives. The following is an example that is due to Charles Travis, who uses this and other examples to argue for what is called 'radical contextualism'.[3]

Suppose your friend is a botanist who is studying the role of chlorophyll in photosynthesis. She needs a couple of green leaves to do an experiment. You happen to have some red leaves that are painted green, and some naturally green leaves. You give her the latter, not the former, saying "Here are some green leaves." What you say is true. Another friend of yours is an interior decorator who is designing a shop window. He needs some green leaves to contrast with a burgundy red dress. You give him the painted ones, saying again: "Here are some green leaves." Again, what you say is true.

At least, that is what Travis claims. Would you agree?

Group 2:
"Strawson notes that '[…] where the use of sentences and expressions is overtly fictional, the sense of the word "about" may change.' [331] This suggest that referring use in fiction is possible. Is that then the same as referring use in non-fictional context? For example, is what is 'implied' in Strawson's sense the same in both cases?"

The question of truth and reference in fiction is an intriguing one. It is not the question of truth *of* fiction, of course. In some cases that is a relevant question, e.g., when we are dealing with a so-called 'key novel', where some fictional characters are based on actual people or where fictional events correspond with actual events. But that applies only to specific fictional works and in any case is a question for literary studies, not one for philosophy or logic. The philosophical-logical question is whether it makes sense to state claims about fictional characters or fictional events that can be evaluated in terms of truth/falsity and that hence raise questions of the reference of expressions occurring in such claims. Thus, we can, for example, discuss the motives of the protagonist in a novel ('Why did Anna Karenina leave her husband for Vronsky?'), reminding ourselves of events in their past, of their family relations, their romantic involvements, and so on. Claims about why the protagonist acted in a certain way can then be true or false, which means that names and descriptions that are used in formulating these claims can refer successfully or fail to refer. Within the world created by the fiction such claims that can be meaningful and truth-evaluable.

It is interesting to note that such claims may extend to matters that are not explicitly stated in the text itself. Often things are left implicit but nevertheless they can be decided, or at least meaningfully discussed, in terms of what is explicitly stated. Good fiction is never exhaustive.

[3] See, for example, his *Occasion Sensitivity: Selected Essays*, Oxford: OUP, 2008.

(Fiction that is, is quite boring.) However, unlike in the case of actual reality, there are still limits to what can be meaningfully asked, asserted, or denied, in fiction. A simple example. In real life the question of a person's ancestry makes sense, at least it makes sense going back a number of generations. It may not be easy to answer, and, in some cases, it may not be answerable at all, but it does make sense. However, in the context of a work of fiction that very same question is usually completely undetermined, and hence meaningless. The same goes for other properties and relations, such family ties. 'How many brothers does Godot have?' We can't even answer the question who Godot is, or whether he exists in the first place …[4]

Group 3:
"According to Strawson knowing the meaning does not presuppose knowing about any particular use. Is that plausible? Shouldn't one have at least knowledge of some particular uses? (Consider learning.)"

From the perspective of first language acquisition, it seems quite obvious that use comes first: use is what the pre-verbal infant is confronted with, what it hears, -directed to itself or to others-, what it reacts to, what it imitates, and what starts trying to produce itself. Meaning in the Strawsonian sense, of habits and conventions that regulate use, comes as a *product* of that first exposure to, and experiment with, use. And that means that whatever we learn in that way is meaning that, *pace* Strawson, *does* involve knowledge of particular uses. (Think of learning your own name as a very clear example.) The case of uniquely referring expressions does not appear to be an exception as far as acquisition is concerned. We first learn to use them and only on the basis of that we acquire their meanings.

This is all from the perspective of first language acquisition. But once we are competent language users our language does continue to expand. We continue to learn new expressions, new phrases, new ways of saying things, and we do so basically our entirely lives. Some of that might appear to fit Strawson's claim better. When we are introduced to a new discipline, say physics, we learn a lot of new expressions: 'mass', 'force', 'field', … Do we learn these by first being exposed to particular uses of those terms? That seems difficult to decide, if only because 'particular use' in the case of theoretical terms such as these is not a very clear concept. Minimally, what we can observe is that in such cases there is a clear distinction between lay people and experts. In some cases, it seems that lay people's knowledge of, say, electrons, is really not much more that a very general meaning in the Strawsonian sense: a (loose) definition, a couple of stock phrases. But the kind of meaningful discussion that experts can have about electrons, which is where the actual uses of the terms are exhibited, is beyond the layperson's reach. Knowing what 'electron' means and knowing what an electron is, are for many people two quite different things. But knowing what 'brother' means and knowing what a brother is, are not.[5]

And there are all kinds of interesting mixed cases. Take artificial intelligence. Most people have no real knowledge of what that is in the sense of knowing how it works, e.g., knowing how LLMs are constructed, what data they operate on, how they are trained. But they do have knowledge of how and where artificial intelligence is used, and of how they themselves can make use of it, e.g., by using a chatbot. Most complex technologies that have applications in the real world, especially those that have applications in daily life, exhibit this Janus-faced nature. Do lay

[4] See John Woods, *Truth in Fiction: Rethinking its Logic,* Springer, 2018, for detailed analyses by one of the pioneers of this area of research.
[5] To be more precise, for a speaker of English knowing what 'brother' means and knowing what a brother is are not different. And analogously for speakers of other languages.

people know what *X* is? Yes and no. It really depends on the context in which we ask the question. So, do they know what '*X*' means? Or does that also depend on the context?[6]

Group 4:
"A sentence is significant, according to Strawson, if it could be used to make a true/false assertion [329]. Then what about the following sentence: 'The truth of Goldbach's conjecture remains unproven.'? "

A sentence such as this presents a conundrum for Strawson. According to him, a sentence containing a definite description in subject position can be made to make a true or false statement provided the description is used in a uniquely referring way. Now it would appear that this sentence actually says something that is true: after all, Goldbach's conjecture is exactly that: a conjecture. However, Strawson's analysis requires that the phrase 'the truth of Goldbach's conjecture' is used in a uniquely referring way. And that seems not to be the case here. In terms of what such use 'implies', in Strawson' sense: anyone who would utter this sentence sincerely, i.e., believing that what it states is true, is thereby committed to *not* believing that the description refers. Another way of seeing that this is what Strawson's account is committed to is to note that if you believe that this sentence is true, you *ipso facto* also believe that the following sentence is also true: 'The falsity of Goldbach's conjecture remains unproven.' And under the assumption the Goldbach's conjecture is no exception to the law of non-contradiction this leaves one in a very uncomfortable state.

Note that Strawson might retort that what we actually mean to express by this sentence is something like: 'Whether Goldbach's conjecture is true, remains unproven.' That works, but it severely undermines Strawson's criticism of Russell. For this is a form of *re-analysis* that is Russellian in nature: it forgets about the subject-predicate structure of the original sentence and claims that that structure is actually misleading as to what it is about. Such a way out is therefore not open to Strawson, and that means that examples such as these are not adequately covered by his approach.

[6] A classical paper on these issues is Hilary Putnam, 'The Meaning of "Meaning"', *Minnesota Studies in the Philosophy of Science*, vol. 7, 1975. For an analysis of the situation with generative AI systems, see M. Stokhof, 'On Travelling Concepts, *Proceedings of the Paris Institute for Advanced Studies*, vol. 21, 2025.